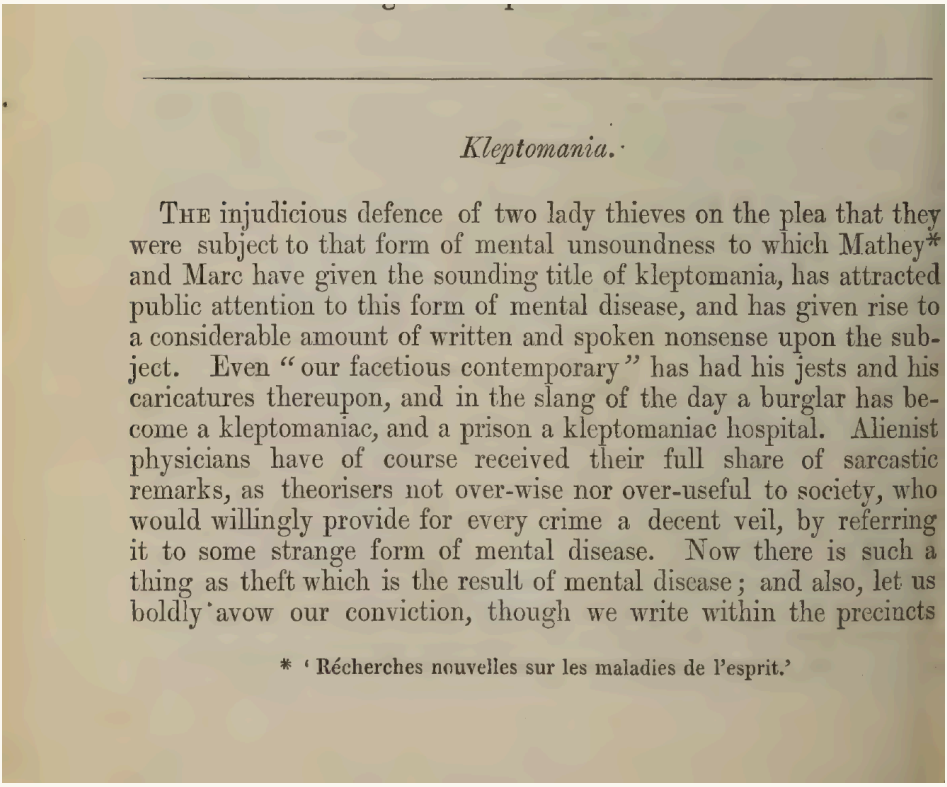


Kleptomania.

THE injudicious defence of two lady thieves on the plea that they were subject to that form of mental unsoundness to which Mathey* and Marc have given the sounding title of kleptomania, has attracted public attention to this form of mental disease, and has given rise to a considerable amount of written and spoken nonsense upon the subject. Even "our facetious contemporary" has had his jests and his caricatures thereupon, and in the slang of the day a burglar has become a kleptomaniac, and a prison a kleptomaniac hospital. Alienist physicians have of course received their full share of sarcastic remarks, as theorisers not over-wise nor over-useful to society, who would willingly provide for every crime a decent veil, by referring it to some strange form of mental disease. Now there is such a thing as theft which is the result of mental disease; and also, let us boldly avow our conviction, though we write within the precincts

* 'Récherches nouvelles sur les maladies de l'esprit.'

'Kleptomania', *The Journal of Mental Science*

July 1862 · Vol. 8, pp. 262–275 · British psychiatric journal · Reproduction of page 262

The article opens with 'the injudicious defence of two lady thieves' on the plea of kleptomania. Writing like this gave families and courts a medical account of shoplifting to set against a criminal one. The full article is on the desk.

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